

THREADS OF BECOMING

By

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To the Faculty of Washington State University:

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THREADS OF BECOMING

Abstract

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Chair: Squeak Meisel

We are born into structures shaped by culture and society. From a young age, we are taught how to walk, talk, feel, and behave. These lessons are imparted through education, parental expectations, religion, laws, and governmental systems. Language frames these intricate rules and knowledge. But is it possible to question this conditioning and truly understand who we are beyond such structures?

As an immigrant who moved from Vietnam to the United States nearly ten years ago, my experience of adapting to a new culture, language, and societal framework has profoundly shaped my identity. This journey has taught me resilience and adaptability. It has also shown me the importance of questioning my beliefs, unlearning what I have been taught, rethinking what has been coded into my mind, and unfolding the structures that have shaped my understanding of the world, and ultimately, taught me how to live.

This thesis explores the process of self-reconstruction within the immigrant experience, examining how cultural displacement challenges notions of identity and belonging. *Threads of Becoming* includes works that reflect a personal journey of self-discovery and adaptation, but they also extend beyond the personal, gesturing toward a collective process of transformation. By

engaging with these installations and performances, viewers are invited to participate in this unfolding: to move, to reflect, to become. In the space of art, we are free to construct new languages, new ways of seeing, and new ways of being. We can weave, unweave, and weave again, with each stitch becoming a step toward reimagining what is possible.

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Dedication

To those caught between worlds

To those who feel out of place,
or caught between the pulse of many lands
May you find the courage
to embrace your becoming,
like a river learning its shape
with every bend.

May you uncover strength
in the hush of uncertainty,
where not knowing
is fertile ground
for something beautifully unknown.

May you be patience
yes, be it
sit softly with transformation,
as seeds do before the bloom.

May you delight
in the unfolding,
in discovering,
the endless galaxies within yourself.

This is for the ones who dare
to question,
to dream,
to craft a path that never existed before
a path lit by your own becoming.

THREADS OF BECOMING: THE WORKS

My thesis show consists of five works: four performance art videos and one large-scale interactive 3D knit work. These works explore the tension between control and release, structure and transformation, personal history and speculative futures. Art becomes a space for expanding consciousness, breaking free from limitations, and seeing beyond the rigid structures that define us.

MIND: MEDITATING

In the first two performance video works: *Waves of Transmission* (Fig.1) and *Between Stillness and Bloom* (Fig.2), I sit motionless at the center as electronic waves flow through and around me, enveloping my body in an invisible yet ever-present force. This stillness mirrors the early stage of a butterfly: an in-between space of transformation where old structures dissolve, and something new begins to take form. The waves, like cultural codes and societal expectations, move through me, shaping and reshaping my existence. Yet, within this suspended state, there is also potential: a quiet resistance, a moment of incubation where identity is neither fixed nor fully formed. These works reflect on the unseen processes of becoming, questioning how we internalize and transform the world around us.

Friedrich Nietzsche emphasizes solitude as a space for self-discovery and intellectual growth. He suggests that solitude is necessary for deep reflection and the cultivation of wisdom. In *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, Nietzsche portrays solitude as the essential condition for personal development. Zarathustra spends ten years alone in the mountains, using that time to reflect and engage with his thoughts, accumulating wisdom much like a bee collecting honey. Solitude gives Zarathustra the space to evolve intellectually and spiritually.¹ I relate to Nietzsche's ideas, as I found solitude to be a space of transformation. When I first arrived in the U.S. without knowing English, I faced profound isolation. I spent hours in the library, slowly teaching myself the language, reading, and sitting in silence to think. This solitude became my lifeline. Later, the art

¹ Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra: A Book for All and None*, read *First Part: Zarathustra's Discourses*, trans. Thomas Common (Project Gutenberg, December 1, 1999), <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1998>.

studio became my new solitude—a space where my thoughts could unfold freely, and where I could strip away the learned structures of culture and expectation to glimpse what lies beneath.

As someone who often feels suspended between two worlds—cultures, languages, past and future—art offers me a space of my own, unbound by either side. When I feel stuck or lost, art becomes my light. It helps me create my own imaginative space where I can relearn how to see, feel, and move forward. In that space, I am free to question, explore, remember, and dream. Art gives me permission to exist fully, in all my complexities.

BODY: INTERACTIVE

The interactive installation in this body of work is a large-scale, immersive 3D knit piece: *Threads of Becoming* (Fig.3) that reacts to viewers' movements, creating a dynamic interplay between presence and form. Woven threads tighten and release in real-time, transforming the structure into a living system that breathes, shifts, and adapts. Projected visuals ripple across three expansive screens, merging the tactile with the digital and blurring the boundaries between the physical body and virtual space.

As viewers move through the installation, they trigger both sound and visual motion, becoming acutely aware of how their bodies influence the environment: and how, in turn, the environment shapes them. The work invites participants to reflect on their presence, behavior, and identity within shifting contexts. This awareness mirrors my own experience as an immigrant in America, navigating how external systems affect internal transformations.

Knitting, an ancient craft rooted in repetition and meditation, becomes a bridge to contemporary digital systems: both relying on patterns, loops, and coded structures to generate form. In this work, knitting and computation intertwine as metaphors for transformation: the interwoven threads represent the frameworks that shape us, while their ability to shift and reconfigure suggests the possibility of change. This piece explores the embodied experience of transformation, offering participants an opportunity to feel how presence and motion can reshape their interaction with space and form. It is a tactile dialogue between the human body and its surrounding environment, an exploration of how our actions ripple through the systems we inhabit.

SOUL: BECOMING

The final two video works delve deeper into transformation and self-liberation. In the third video, *Unravel* (Fig.4), I attempt to break my braided hair, which is connected to a string embroidered with words: a delicate yet persistent struggle. The braid, an extension of my body, becomes both a tether and a symbol of identity, entangled with external expectations. The string represents the invisible forces that bind us: cultural codes, inherited beliefs, and societal constraints, while the slow yet determined effort to sever it embodies the resilience required to break free and redefine oneself. This act of struggle and release reflects the tension between holding onto the past and the necessity of letting go to evolve.

In the final video, *WovenSoul* (Fig.5), I am underneath a crochet blanket, dancing in a playful and uninhibited manner. This movement represents a moment of emergence, a shedding of self-consciousness, and an embrace of authenticity. The blanket, at first a covering, suggests societal pressures or imposed roles, barriers that obscure individuality. Yet, as I move freely within it, reshaping its form, I reclaim space for self-expression. This work celebrates the soul's journey to become: a playful, joyful unfolding of identity that defies imposed constraints and embraces creative freedom.

ART: A SPACE FOR CONSCIOUSNESS EXPANSION

From stillness and meditation to movement and becoming, my artistic journey in the U.S. reflects a process of inner transformation. Throughout my practice, I have come to see art as a space to break free from rigid structures and expand perception. As an immigrant, my initial struggle with language barriers led to a period of depression: a sense of being lost within an unfamiliar framework. Art became a refuge, a way of navigating the unknown, a method of reconstructing meaning beyond the limitations of language. It allowed me to see life not as a fixed set of rules but as an open-ended process of exploration, curiosity, and becoming.

In many ways, I see a deep resonance between my approach and the work of Yayoi Kusama. Her practice, shaped by early family opposition and lifelong struggles with mental health, offers a powerful testament to how art can become a means of survival, expression, and transformation. Kusama's work: ranging from paintings and performance to immersive installations and fashion embodies obsession, hallucination, and imagination as modes of truth-telling. Like Kusama, I believe in the power of process to reveal hidden dimensions of thought and feeling. Kusama's hallucinatory visions and immersive spaces offer a radical reimagining of perception, blurring the lines between art and life, self and other.

In one interview, Yayoi Kusama said: "I've sought for truth of art with an ambition and fought like hell all my life to accomplish my purpose as a human being. Even after I finish my life, I'd like to keep telling posterity about my way of art."² Like Kusama, art makes me feel alive: it helps me understand my life's purpose and allows me to question the nature of existence. I view

² Kharas, Jodie. "Quick Five: Yayoi Kusama." *Tate*, May 27, 2015

the act of making to leave behind a trace of being a continuum of emotion and thought that stretches far beyond the limits of the physical self.

Art is a process of growth. It is a journey of learning, reflection, and experimentation. In this way, art becomes more than a practice—it becomes a way of living. As Kusama has shown through decades of relentless creation, art can be a response to pain, a celebration of life, and an ever-evolving expression of being in the world.

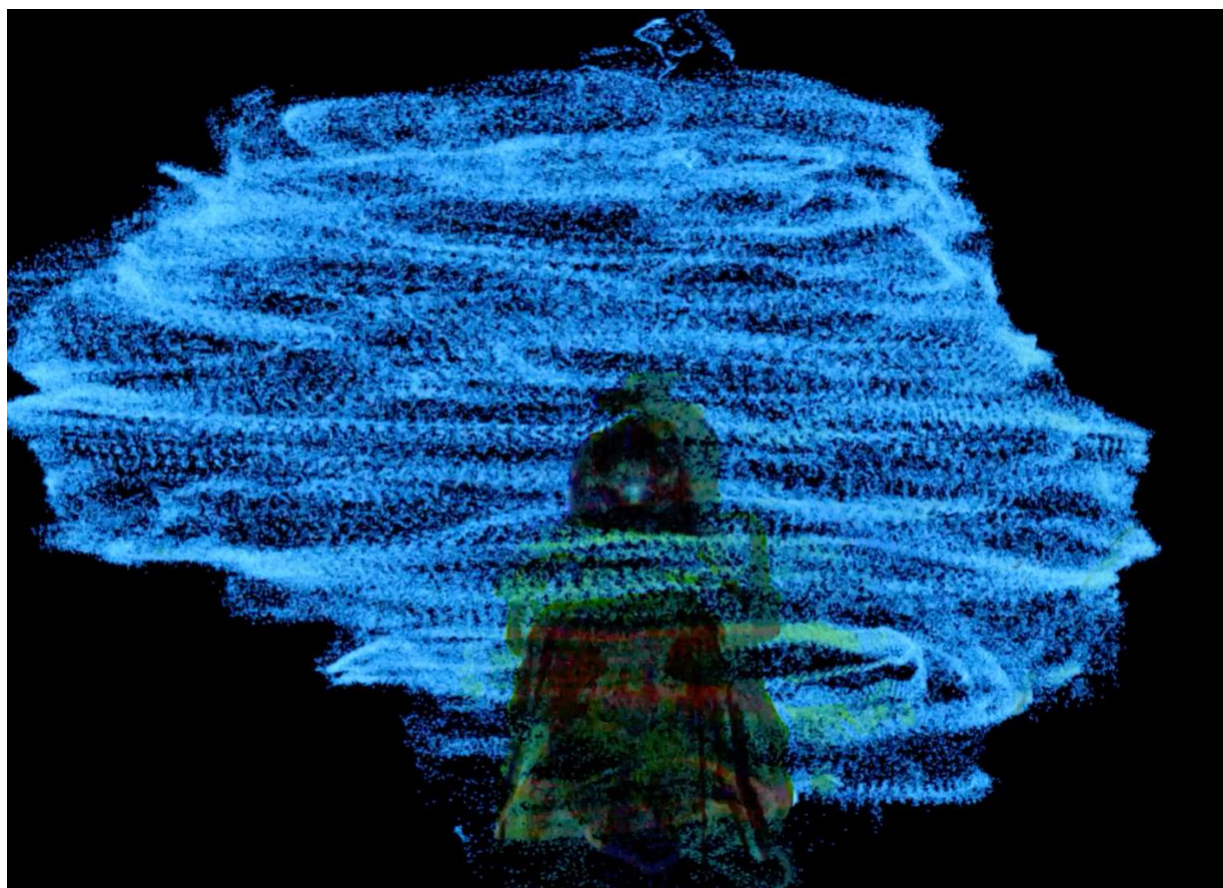


Fig. 1: *Waves of Transmission*, 2024. Video art on TV screen.



Fig. 2: *Between Stillness and Bloom*, 2024. Video art on TV screen

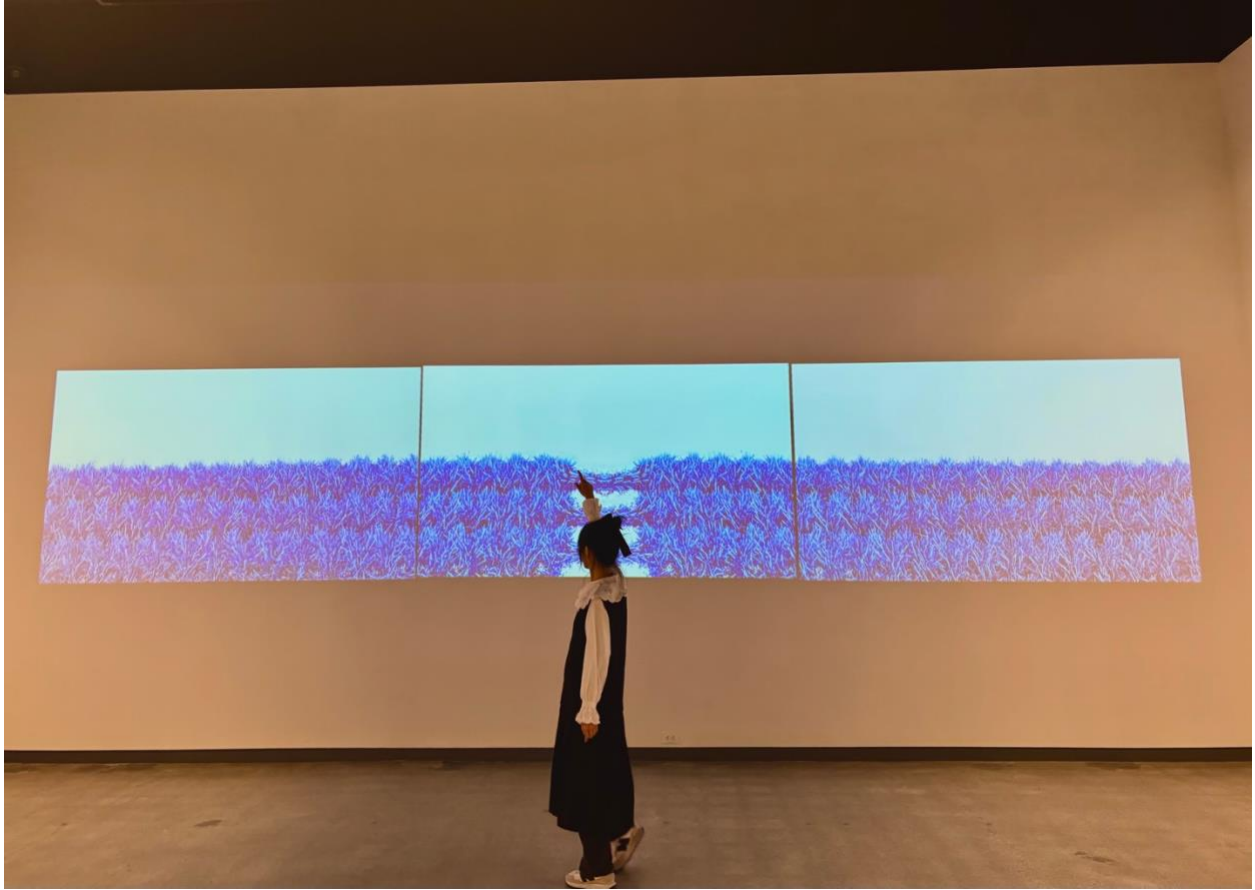


Fig. 3: *Threads of Becoming*, 2024. Sound/Visual interactive on multi-projectors.



Fig. 4: *Unravel*, 2024. Video art on TV screen



Fig. 5: *WovenSoul*, 2024. Video art on TV screen

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